



**FIRST-GRADERS** raise their hands on the first day of school at Gledhill Street Elementary in North Hills. CHRISTINA HOUSE Los Angeles Times

## State cuts excessive tests for English learners

New law streamlines program so students can get on with broader education.

By Emily Woodruff

In a major overhaul of a decades-old practice, nearly 1 million California students designated as English learners will no longer have to pass a battery of tests and benchmarks to move out of a program that advocates say has long been holding back their education, under a new law signed by Gov. Gavin Newsom on Sunday.

Assembly Bill 2555 dismantles and streamlines an aging system that some researchers said kept far too many students classified as English learners months or even years after mastering the language. Under the new law, students will have to pass only one state-approved English assessment to show they are proficient.

“It is a big win,” said Nancy Villarreal, executive director of Parent Organization Network, an advocacy group for families. “This bill will ... remove all the extra hoops they have to jump through, but also make sure that the students will continue having some extra support.”

There are just under a million designated English learners in California schools — roughly 1 in 6 students in kindergarten through 12th grade. This formal classification means that students receive specialized English-language instruction during the school day, largely funded by the state.

The problem, supporters of the new law said, is that it has been far too difficult to pass out of the program — with different requirements in districts throughout the state — and has caused confusion for parents and families.

Between 2022 and 2024, an estimated 37,000 California students scored at the highest level on the standardized English Language Proficiency Assessments for California, known as the EL-PAC, but remained classified as English learners the following school year, according to University of Oregon research.

On average, it took more than 220 calendar days for students to be reclassified, according to the California Department of Education. One in 10 waited at least 532 days. A school year in California is 180 days. Some stu-

[See English, A14]

## Taunts and bans: Trump escalates his war on press

Attacks come at shaky time for public trust in media

By Michael Wilner

WASHINGTON — Under a light rain on Sunday at the Australian ambassador’s residence in Washington, CNN hosted its third annual tennis tournament, the Kangaroo Cup, pitting Beltway journalists against administration officials. The event aims to inject some levity into a historically adversarial relationship, reminding both sides of the spirit of the game. Themed drinks and tennis whites set the tone.

White House officials played with grace. But the mood this year was altogether different down Pennsylvania Avenue. Despite a federal judge demanding the administration reverse course on President Trump’s punitive actions toward his disfavored news outlets — CNN, MS NOW and Politico — he has refused to resume full access to the storied cable news channel, dismissing its reporters as “fake news.”

It is only the latest attack on press freedom by a president whose drive to punish

critics and exert influence over the media appears to be growing.

During last week’s lavish state visit for Xi Jinping, Trump praised China for having “the friendliest press corps” and dismissed its repression of speech, despite the World Press Freedom Index ranking China among the world’s worst offenders — at the bottom of the list, alongside North Korea and Eritrea — for restrictions on journalists.

Five times in the last two months, the president has

[See Attacks, A6]

## Self-regulation may be AI firms’ goal

By Garance Burke

SAN FRANCISCO — As tech titans warned an AI-weary world that their own advanced systems could endanger humanity, the question emerged: What do they have to gain?

The answer may lie in the companies’ efforts to score political goals ahead of the

U.S. midterm elections and the money that top artificial intelligence labs and their investors stand to make in much-anticipated listings on a jittery stock market.

The chief executives of Anthropic and OpenAI recently declared America’s cutting-edge models are so powerful that they’re dangerous and need to be regulated and independently

tested before being released. In a rare instance of unity, they and other AI companies have sketched alarming scenarios in essays, social media posts and speeches to the United Nations.

Along the way, they are shaping the conversation around how their technology should be controlled. With their rhetoric, the com-

[See AI, A11]

## Across IVF insurance divide, many priced out of parenthood

By Sarah Elizabeth Richards

In February, when 40-year-old Nicole Torres visited her OB-GYN at Cedars-Sinai Medical Center in Los Angeles to discuss why the recent nine-week ultrasound of her pregnancy had shown no heartbeat, she felt

relieved to at least have clear next steps. Her doctor had given her a referral for an infertility specialist.

Torres was hopeful about the timing, too. She had learned about a new law requiring insurance companies to cover infertility diagnoses and treatment, specifically in vitro fertilization. Considered by fertility doc-

tors to be the most effective medical intervention — in which eggs are surgically removed and combined with sperm inside a lab to create embryos that are transferred to the uterus — IVF is also the most expensive. A single cycle including medication costs about \$25,000 in Los Angeles, and many peo-

[See IVF, A14]



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

**NICOLE** Torres doesn’t qualify for infertility treatment coverage under state law.

## New U.S. fuel rules are a blow to climate goals

California and other states are likely to sue over lower mileage standards for vehicles.

By Hayley Smith

The Trump administration on Monday released new fuel-efficiency rules that loosen pressure on automakers to control pollution from gasoline-powered vehicles, further complicating California’s ability to meet its climate and clean car goals.

President Trump pitched the changes, which he announced in December, as a way to boost the domestic auto industry and lower consumer costs. He made the original announcement standing alongside several auto executives.

The new rule applies to Corporate Average Fuel Economy Standards, or CAFE Standards, which have been implemented by the federal government since the 1970s, when cars averaged about 13 miles per gallon.

The change will set the requirement for 2031 model-year vehicles to 34.9 miles per gallon, when it would have been 50.4 miles per gallon under rules from the Biden administration. U.S. Transportation Secretary Sean Duffy said the move will end the “illegal mandate that forced automakers to produce more expensive electric vehicles that American families didn’t want.”

“With our commonsense standards in place, we are

making the American dream affordable again, putting safer cars on the road, and investing in the American autoworker,” Duffy said in a statement.

But experts say the plan enables automakers to manufacture and sell larger, heavier and less fuel-efficient vehicles in states across the country.

“What this rule does is sends a signal to the auto industry that they don’t have to make their vehicles more efficient, and they don’t have to create vehicles that will save drivers money anymore,” said Kathy Harris, director of clean vehicles, climate and energy at the non-profit Natural Resources Defense Council. “It’s just focusing on the cost [to] industry and ignoring the real affordability crisis that Californians and Americans are really feeling right now.”

Monday’s action will hit people’s wallets hard, Harris said. Californians are already facing extremely high costs at the pump, with gasoline averaging about \$6.37 a gallon in the state, according to AAA.

Only the federal government is allowed to set miles-per-gallon rules. But to address climate change, and the role of cars in it, California has required vehicles to emit less carbon dioxide per mile.

The Trump administration recognizes this and also has moved to revoke California’s authority over tailpipe requirements, as well as its ambitious plan to ban the sale of new gasoline-powered cars in 2035.

When taken together, the

[See Mileage, A11]

## Trapped on violent deportation flight

Bewildered men recount journey to an African nation plagued by conflict.

By Kate Linticum

On a tarmac in Texas, federal agents repeatedly ordered a group of shackled immigrants off a bus and onto an airplane that they had heard was destined for Africa.

Many complied, but some men refused. They had sought protection in the U.S. after fleeing repressive governments and asked to speak to lawyers before being deported to a faraway continent.

“Tell us where you’re taking us,” Kenis Adalberto López, a 44-year-old from Nicaragua, said he told immigration agents through tears. “I’d rather die here than in Africa.”

Eventually, an agent boarded the bus and fired pepper balls at the men, according to interviews with three of them. López, who was hit twice in the chest with projectiles, said he was strapped to a stretcher and carried onto the plane, where he was restrained for

the roughly 24-hour journey to Bangui, the capital of the Central African Republic.

More than 25,000 people have been expelled from the U.S. under a Trump administration program to deport asylum seekers and other migrants to “third countries” where they have no ties.

A federal appeals court ordered a pause on the program last week, saying the government failed to give migrants “a meaningful opportunity” to challenge their deportations to third countries. The Trump administration vowed to take the case to the Supreme Court, with Atty. Gen. Todd Blanche describing the program as “an entirely legal and invaluable tool to stem the tide of illegal immigration.”

The administration has routinely said that its enforcement operations are carried out in compliance with federal law and that detainees are treated humanely.

The Aug. 29 deportation of López and 42 others to Bangui highlights the sometimes violent tactics that officials have used to force detainees onto flights out of the U.S. — and the perils

[See Deportees, A3]

**New Burbank terminal put to the test**  
Volunteers recruited for a trial run of \$1.3-billion airport facility give it high marks. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

**State oversight for Kaiser system**  
The attorney general will help monitor the arbitration process for fairness. **BUSINESS, A9**

**Weather**  
Sunny.  
L.A. Basin: 89/66. **B6**

**Markets ..... A11**  
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**Dawn of new era for the Lakers**  
At media day, Doncic and Reeves show they’re ready to lead the storied franchise. **SPORTS, B10**

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